

Saying times and making appointments

Teaching guide

Agree on an unambiguous time.

Understand the distinction

You can say 9:15 as nine fifteen or a quarter past nine. 9:45 can be nine forty-five or a quarter to ten. Digital forms are often easiest when confirming an appointment.

Use a.m. or p.m. when the part of the day is unclear. Noon is midday; midnight is the start of a new day in date-based schedules. Include the date and time zone for an international meeting. Confirm rather than guess.

Compare the patterns

PAST THE HOUR

a quarter past nine

9:15

BEFORE THE HOUR

a quarter to ten

9:45

CONFIRM

Is that 9 a.m. Tokyo time?

Clarify the time zone and part of day.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Which time is half past two?

A. 2:30

B. 2:15

C. 1:30

2. Which time is a quarter to six?

A. 5:45

B. 6:45

C. 6:15

3. What should you clarify in Let's meet at eight if you are in different countries?

A. The date, a.m. or p.m., and time zone.

B. Only whether eight is written as a digit or a word.

C. Only the length of the meeting.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which message gives an exact appointment date and time and asks about the time zone?

- A. Let's meet soon. Is that London time?
- B. Let's meet on 12 September at 10 a.m. Is that London time?
- C. Let's meet on 12 September at ten. I will see you then.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. 2:30

Half past means thirty minutes after the hour.

B: Half past means 30 minutes after the hour, not 15.

C: Half past two is 30 minutes after two, not before it.

2. A. 5:45

It is fifteen minutes before six.

B: 6:45 is a quarter to seven, not six.

C: A quarter to six is 15 minutes before six; 6:15 is a quarter past.

3. A. The date, a.m. or p.m., and time zone.

A complete appointment avoids assumptions.

B: The possible confusion is the actual date and time zone, not the spelling.

C: Duration does not clarify when the meeting starts.

4. B. Let's meet on 12 September at 10 a.m. Is that London time?

It includes the date, clock time, a.m., and a time-zone check.

A: Soon does not give the required date and clock time.

C: Ten leaves a.m./p.m. unclear, and no time zone is checked.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-31.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which message gives an exact appointment date and time and asks about the time zone?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.